

king

pta, 34 &
pta, 32

nging
al
to desi

N Ray Kroc,
was the first
McDonald's

ending
1,500
r at
urants

"But it wasn't easy to convince bakers to make a special round pav. We needed about 4,000 units which was too little and too much trouble for the bakers," says Dheeraj. But he and wife Reeta stuck to their guns. And the baker who refused them half a decade ago today must be cursing his luck even as Choice Bakers and Bread Kraft grin while providing the 40,000 pavs that Jumbo King consumes every day, along with two tonnes of potatoes.

The journey of bringing standardisation to a business that is unorganised has been one of trial and error as the Guptas had no benchmark. From convincing his halwai to not make the vada with his hands but use instead an ice-cream scoop to sticking a thermometer in the frying pan in order to check the temperature at which the vada fries, Dheeraj put his Dadar catering college days to good use. The cou-

UHASHAK PAUL

FOOD TO GLORY: Dheeraj and Reeta at their first outlet in Mumbai

ple soon introduced transfer bins like the ones at McDonald's and started serving the snack in a wrapper, something the average vada pav consumer hadn't held before. "My father said this international concept wouldn't work with a food so local. But within three months of getting transfer bins, our sales doubled," he says. From selling just 3,000 units, Jumbo King's first outlet started handing out 6,000 units as the hygiene angle clicked with the consumers.

Once commuters at Malad (East) station got the hang of the pick-and-move concept, Dheeraj knew that it was time for the "second outlet and soon the third. This was also the time when the couple went back to McDonald's and decided to replicate the franchisee model. "Now all our Jumbo King outlets are franchises," say the Guptas, who started with a staff of five uneducated helpers and had only each other to bounce ideas off. "All our office battles would continue into the bedroom," says 32-year-old Reeta. But today they are a team of 300 people, with another 100 working at the 42 operational kitchens across the city. Instead of a 50 sq ft hole that they worked out of, they have a 1,000 sq ft office and are looking for one triple the current size.

Jumbo King's story is almost phoenix-like. The Guptas' current venture emerged only after Dheeraj suffered losses in an ambitious project that never took off. He wanted to package Indian mithai as an FMCG product so that people could buy packs for individual consumption like chocolates. "I took a loan of Rs 15 lakh from a bank but the proposition was very expensive and it didn't take off," he says. His Marwari businessman father was not happy and for a year Dheeraj lay low, assisting in the family business before spreading his wings again. With much trepidation, he approached his father to let him use half of a family-owned milk shop that wasn't doing well. "My father still can't believe that an educated man can be happy selling vada pav," smiles Dheeraj.

That was six years ago. Today, he has his eyes firmly set on the calendar. By March 2009 he wants to open Jumbo King's 300th outlet and expand to cities like Delhi, Hyderabad and Bangalore, besides growing in Gujarat, where he recently set foot. "We're going to sell vada pav as Mumbai's favourite food. It's going to be an aspirational snack," says Dheeraj whose company is looking at a projected turnover of Rs 40 crore. Till he achieves that, the lazy boy will have to wait. ■

